Chapter 5
Comparative Classics, Comparative Philosophy

The preceding chapter has attempted a general reading of ancient Chinese classics, and has done so by focusing on some features which, in my view, need to be kept in mind when "comparing" Chinese philosophy with other thought systems and worldview. I have insisted upon the fact (a) that by fostering attentiveness, Chinese classics nurture an experiential form of thinking; (b) that they mean to *achieve* something, endowing signs, graphs and texts with a special, performative status; (c) that they focus less on notions than on patterns; and also (this point would deserve further developments) (d) that they do not absolutize these patterns but rather work towards their assumption: "The perfect image has no shape" (*Daodejng* 41) – a sentence that also applies to the encoding of the Way that classics operate. The combination of these features creates a given *style*, a style that any comparative endeavor needs to appreciate and respect. At the same time, identifying such features may help us to highlight characteristics present in other thought systems, as rhetorical features bear upon our understanding of their authors' ways of proceeding and ultimate motives. This chapter will keep in mind the Chinese style of thinking as it starts to articulate more general, more theoretical propositions.

From Notions to Motions

Throughout the course of the first three chapters, I have at times directed criticisms towards current attempts at doing philosophy comparatively. This should not hinder us from recognizing their merits: they put into relationship traditions of thought that, for centuries, were following parallel trajectories. They show much creativity in their way of rethinking and re-interpreting concepts and categories that their positioning into specific languages and systems had sometimes stultified. They renew the issues that world philosophy can and should confront. Actually, the difficulties with which several of these attempts are meeting may be summarized by one question: what does it mean to "compare" philosophical traditions? Can it be truly equated with the fact of establishing sets of contrasts? Let us risk a tentative definition of the method and purpose associated with a renewed understanding of what "comparative philosophy" is about:

Doing comparative philosophy means to think and operate dialogically, i. e., to unceasingly circulate from one's original tradition to the thought and corpus with which a privileged and transformative relationship is taking shape. And when several thinkers starting from different standpoints are consciously engaged into the

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same task, then this dialogical relationship becomes *mutually transformative* of the traditions being considered.

I now explore the consequences of the definition I have just formulated. I will start by some quick remarks about the first period of the Sino-Western philosophical encounter (c. 1600 – 1730), remarks that do not aim at drawing an historical picture of the events it triggered but rather at anchoring what will follow into a point of departure. Afterwards, I will address two questions: (1) What does "thinking dialogically" entail? (2) How can we read and interpret texts (classics) interculturally? The developments authorized by these two questions will help us to suggest, not exactly a method, but rather a *style* congruent with the approach to comparative philosophy I suggest here.

The process through which Aristotelian and scholastic vocabulary and logic were introduced into China has aroused great interest in recent years.[126] The conclusions to be drawn from these studies remain uncertain: the first attempts to translate Aristotle into Chinese were very partial and still embarrassed by problems of terminology that would take much time to unravel. Missionaries themselves were not in agreement as to the importance to be given to the introduction of Western philosophy, or to which system to favor. Moreover, they were relying on the philosophy and logic textbooks they had used during their studies in Europe (first and foremost those used at the Jesuit college of Coimbra, Portugal) rather than on Greek originals. Their thought was permeated by scholasticism and Aristotelianism, even if Jesuit training was far from being influenced solely by Thomism. It is therefore less in a particular text or translation than in the way they argued and organized their works that one can discern how Western philosophy entered China. This is especially true during the 17th century. From the 1680s onwards, the arrival of French missionaries went hand in hand with a less Aristotelian and more Cartesian tone. More importantly, missionary culture began to be shaped by the in-depth assimilation of Chinese texts, notably of the *Four Books*, which were translated, studied, commented upon, which quite naturally changed the style of argumentation. Some Jesuits – François Noël (1651 – 1729) for instance – even apprehended and appreciated the logic and concepts proper to Neo-Confucianism, whereas Ricci and his immediate successors were referring only to "original" Confucianism, latter-day expressions being in their view contaminated with Buddhism (Meynard 2018). We must therefore avoid a narrow focus on how such or such a notion was (mis-)translated into Chinese, which would privilege an analysis too philological or conceptual in scope. It is better to take the texts produced throughout a given period of exchange as a constantly evolving whole, and to evaluate their circulation and practical impact. In this overall process, the Aristoteli-

126 Han (2000); Meynard (2015); Witek (1997).

an and scholastic concepts did not represent an isolated continent, and the misunderstandings that occurred around words or characters used in treatises and discussions did not make a meeting of thought and mind impossible. As is the case for all social processes, the one that guides intellectual encounters is messy. And it continuously evolves and develops.

It remains true that polemics bearing specifically on terms on characters and notions to be used, did occur, notably when it came to the Aristotelian concept of "cause" and that, fundamental in all ancient Chinese philosophy, of "transformation" (*hua* 化). In the first chapter I have shown that, when related to the entirety of their respective systems, the opposition between the two is less absolute than generally thought to be. Still, the writings of Matteo Ricci and Giulio Aleni (1582–1649) are already marked by this clash between two logics, which reverberates on the understanding of the Christian concept of creation. Charles Jones aptly sums up the philosophical nature of the confrontation:

> The Jesuits learned from their [textbook commentaries] the Aristotelian view that things do indeed transform from one thing into another, but there is one crucial difference. While the Chinese saw the process of transformation as smooth and seamless, the Jesuits posited a hiatus between a thing and its derivatives: Air does not turn into fire; it returns to subtle being and emerges from that state into fire. This insistence on a hiatus between that which transforms and that which becomes ensured that causes would remain separate from effects. (Jones 2016, 1265)

It remains that the stress should be on the fact that such a debate has been *mutually transformative:* Today, while the study of "logic" as a discipline in China basically follows the model of causation and effects, Aristotelian argumentation no longer appears as a necessary component of Christian theological reasoning. Among other potential pitfalls, it is recognized that it risks distorting the meaning given by the authors of *Genesis* to the creation narrative. If the conceptual debates were probably, and for all parties concerned, the most frustrating of those that engaged Christian missionaries with Chinese literati, they retrospectively relativize the debates that merely center around notions, encouraging one to focus upon the way a sharing of experience among protagonists may produce durable effects. This is the process that Xu Guangqi was inciting Niccolò Longobardo (1565–1655) to delve into when the latter was working on a memoir on Chinese religious worldview – but Longobardo, gathering arguments meant to prove the atheistic nature of Chinese thought, was far too engrossed with scholastic logic and concepts for paying attention to the inner spiritual life of the Converts, who were suggesting to him that a

given term could easily be substituted by another one.[127] Still, the thought process and encounter became progressively, almost naturally *experiential*, for example when the Jesuits began to read the *Zhongyong* through certain categories of the S*piritual Exercises* of Ignatius of Loyola, which describe the *movements* that stir the conscience during self-examination (Mei 2013). This attempt at interpretation – inseparable from an attempt at translation – was incomplete, no doubt partly unconscious, and it possibly produced other kinds of misunderstanding (does one ever progress in understanding other than by dissipating one misunderstanding after another?). But such an interpretative engagement was not only creative but also faithful in spirit to an authentic Confucian intuition: one that refuses to separate meditation from action, and vice versa. On this ground, Jesuit and Confucian conceptions relating to the mutually reinforcing relationship between the discernment of inner motions and engagement into the world were able to come together, this beyond conceptual differences. We will come back to some of these points in the next chapter.

Models of Dialogue

The above already specifies one of the two questions raised at the beginning of this chapter: practically speaking, what does the fact of *meeting and thinking dialogically* mean? Roger Ames presents us with a pessimistic understanding of what "dialogue" entails in the Western tradition:

> In the early days of the Western philosophical narrative, "dialogue" as a form of conversation comes to be understood rather explicitly as "talking through"[128] an issue with the purpose of arriving at truth through the dialectical exchange of logical arguments. For Plato, dialectic is a rational, synoptic ascent in search of "unhypothetized principle (eidos)," while for Aristotle, dialectic entails an analytical descent in the process of taxonomic categorization. I would suggest that it is this understanding of "dialogue" [...] that has allowed philosophy as a professional discipline with its univocal method of "rational argument" and its impatience with any other putative approaches to acquiring knowledge, to become a monologue in its relationship to alternative philosophical traditions. Philosophy understood in such terms can speak, but it

127 On this episode, central for the understanding of the "Term Controversy", see notably Longobardo (1701); Maître (1949); Standaert (1988), 83ff.; Gernet (1982), 45–58.

128 Let me note that translating *dia-logos* by "talking through" is debatable. I prefer the commentary made by Raimon Pannikar: "Dialogue does not seek primarily to be *duo-logue*, a duet of two *logoi*, which would still be dialectical; but a dia-logos, a piercing of the logos to attain a truth that transcends it" (Pannikar 1979, 243).

> cannot listen. A dialogical understanding of philosophy that in its very definition assumes such a monopoly on knowledge might not be open to conversation.
>
> (Ames 2007, 36)

Let me here attempt to *think about dialogue dialogically*, i. e., to mobilize the variety of resources through which dialogue, conversation, exchange or yet *disputatio* are considered, so as to distinguish among the *models of dialogue* that influence the way cross-fertilization – including philosophical cross-fertilization – actually takes place.

Is dialogue the object of a specific field of knowledge? The answer is a qualified "no". For sure, the study of dialogue (the study of the strategies that allow for its unfolding as well as of its social and epistemological implications) aims at constituting itself into an autonomous discipline (sometimes labeled "dialogism" or "dialogic"). However, "dialogue" is less an *object* than a *locus*, a knot, a place of confluence, the examination of which requires that it be broken down into questions relating to disciplines and traditions that are not so easily reduced to each other. The study of dialogue (its conditions, its styles and its implications) is subordinated to the issues that mark out specific fields such as "communication sciences", interreligious dialogue, or yet social sciences when they focus upon the dynamics of labor disputes or international relations for instance.

The difficulty of carrying out an autonomous study of "dialogue" stems in large part from the fact that the word belongs to a class of terms called upon to constantly enlarge their meaning(s) and references – for dialogue happens everywhere. At the same time, the widening of the term goes hand in hand with a specification of the "style" of the activity it refers to. To put it otherwise: the term "dialogue" today preferentially designates a set of attitudes and practices likely to govern the norms of communication to be found in the family, at school, at the office, in therapy, or in exchanges between peoples and cultures. It is the word *style* that matters here – style of communication and style of life inseparably – a *dialogical style* capable of extending to all areas of human activity. However, the generalization of the dialogical style is first of all that of a mode of communication governed by rules, norms and values inscribed in (Western-inspired) modernity. If this is the case, we can understand the reluctance that can be aroused in other cultures by extending dialogical style to all areas of social activity, for example to family relations, to political sociability or to the spiritual and religious field. (Obviously, a "dialogue" between humankind and the godhead constitutes a meaningless proposition for some religious traditions.) The interest in dialogue cannot be "neutral": the description of the rules governing the functioning of dialogue (and the explanation of its possible dysfunctions) does not easily separate cultural, logical, epistemological and ethical registers. "Dialogue" seems to be far too much anchored in

the axioms that govern Western modernity for constituting a neutral, objective methodology.

Our questioning of its apparent neutrality is redoubled by the fact that the term dialogue, in its current meanings, is embedded in a network of notions that it is often difficult to untangle. At a first level, "communication", "exchange", "conversation" or "interaction" act as quasi-synonymous or referential notions. At a second level, terms like "empathy" or "tolerance" suggest the programmatic nature of any dialogical style. The polysemy of the concept cannot be eliminated by a simple terminological "cleaning". Its ambivalences are linked to its history, to its most recent developments, to the cultural baggage that it necessarily carries with it.

We thus need to approach "comparative philosophy" in its dialogical dimension by reflecting upon the cultural depth of the term dialogue and the practices it covers and/or uncovers, sketching out a path: one that starts from the *fragility* of dialogue (notional fragility, fragility of the exercise) in order to think about the universality that constitutes its horizon – and, conversely, to think about "universality" as necessarily sharing the fragility that characterizes dialogue.

There remains a preamble to formulate: there is a constitutive difference between a "conversation" – an oral exchange carried out in a context that defines its rules[129] – and a "written" dialogue (exchange of philosophical letters and arguments for instance), which often seems to be constituted by a series of alternated monologues. Yet, we are dealing here with dialogue as a whole, in the totality of its oral and written expressions, and this because of the circularity that brings them together: not only will a dialogue held orally receive later on a canonical embodiment (this is the case of the Socratic dialogue, or of the conversations recorded in the *Analects*), but also written, canonical dialogues will give way to renewed oral exchanges. Therefore, oral and written dialogues develop over time as in chain. It is precisely their propensity to continue and spread further that will retain our attention.

"Exchanging" Words

The very term dialogue introduces us to the realm of the *exchange of words.* "Exchanging words" enables the interlocutors to test whether or not they share some basic assumptions about the fields of knowledge on which the exchange will

129 For instance, the rules of dialogue in a classroom are not the same as in a United Nations forum.

bear.[130] Knowledge can be of two types – either it relates to a science, for example physics, or it relates to the human being in her nature and her being in society. In the first case, the exchanges take place at the same level of reality as the practical experiments and theoretical formulations through the dialectical sequence of which knowledge of reality progresses: they verify facts and consistency. In the second case, the truth is not mathematical. Its *locus* is that of histories and cultures, to which, in a privileged way, dialogue gives access. It is no longer a question of *verifying* but of *establishing* a relationship, and, in the dialogical exercise, the bringing into relation is reflected in the fact that speaking is coupled with listening. The very mention of the term dialogue and the attention to its contexts therefore makes one distinguish among *orders of truth.* Put otherwise, the determination of different "orders of truth" is linked to the establishing of (logical) relations and of (human) relationships, each of the modes of these connections qualifying as "dialogic style". Let me specify how the joint determination of orders of truth and dialogic styles operates:

– Dialogue understood as a *mere logical exercise* intends to identify propositions that are universally valid and included in a system based on non-contradiction. It is not fundamentally different from what would be the soliloquy of a scientist establishing the validity of a scientific proof. Yet even in the Aristotelian dialectic, the presence (sometimes implicit) of an interlocutor is required in order (a) to ground the principle of non-contradiction (*Met.* Γ4, 1006a); (b) to found propositions which do not belong to the strict domain of science but rather to that of opinion (*doxa*). In other words, in Aristotle, styles of discourse are differentiated according to the nature and hierarchy of truths one is trying to establish (*Met.* B1). More generally, the soliloquy – philosophical or deliberative – is already a *dia-logical* exercise.
– Socratic dialogues are written in a dramatic fashion, the tension being provided by the fact that the very possibility of reaching an agreement will be tested in different ways. They are sort of short dramas culminating in success or failure, with the trial of Socrates illustrating the intensity that dialogical confrontation can ultimately achieve. Livio Rossetti has shown that the formulation of the rules governing Socratic dialogues coincided with the sudden generalization of the term "philosophers" at the very end of the 5th century BCE: the "coding" of the dialogical exercise and the invention of the figure of "the lover of wisdom" were parts of the same enterprise. Besides, the birth of philosophical dialogue as a literary genre coincided with a marked decline in the production of new tragedies (Rossetti 2011, 216 – 217). At a second level, the literary format-

130 For a history of Western-style disputations, see Weijers (2013).

ting of the Socratic dialogues corresponded to an epistemic posture developed by their writer – Plato: Truth is the discovery of unity in and through the multiple, and it is realized and represented by the progressive unity achieved between the protagonists of the dialogue – or else it remains veiled by disagreements and rhetorical loopholes (see Cossuta and Narcy 2001). The dialogical form works as a device for operating *emplotment*.

- In a scholastic-type dialogue, the reference to the principles of "natural light" (i. e., to the shared exercise of reason) is strictly regulated by a textual reference: the texts recognized by the doctrine in question (the canon) define the order of principles and references accepted. The principle of non-contradiction is then exercised within the reading of these texts.
- In contrast, a dialogue of sapiential and educational type, of which the *Analects* of Confucius provides a prime example, is first of all a "dialogue of life" which aims at ensuring that acts and convictions coincide. Dialogue is the gateway through which to make Truth, Path (*dao*) and Life coincide, pointing out the gap that still separates them.[131] Dialogues found in the gospels are very close to this model, but are less *sapiential* in scope than based on a *discernment* to be exercised in the here and now: the emphasis is usually placed on the decision which must come out of the exchange (cf. the dialogue between Jesus and the rich young man in Mark 10, 17–31).
- We could then distinguish different models of "enlightenment" dialogue, in which the *Zhuangz*i or (much later) the Zen Buddhist tradition participate: the dialogue is pushed to a point that precisely breaks the principle of non-contradiction and brings one of the participants to a sudden transformation. In the *Zhuangzi*, in one instance the questioner's "enlightenment" is even expressed by the fact that he falls asleep before the "master" has finished answering (this to the latter's great pleasure: sleep is a sign that the interlocutor has "seen" the inanity of his questioning). The questioner's entry into sleep also avoids the "master" (who did not want to become one) the embarrass-

131 Donald Holzman has given an insightful account of the Chinese "conversational tradition": "It is in the discussion of particular facts of human existence that Confucius, and after him the philosophers in the conversational tradition, produce their particular insights, short, incisive stabs, into the human condition. To organize his insights into a system would be to devitalize them; therefore, his disciples have tried to keep them as close to their original, particular, concrete form as possible and have preserved these Conversations or sayings on different particular occasions. The same can be said for all the later philosophers in the conversational tradition. And the fact that this can be said for later philosophers is important: it shows that the form of the Conversations is not an archaism, the fumbling attempt of the first Chinese philosophers to put their ideas, pell-mell, into some sort of order, but is an integral part of Confucius' thought, and, indeed, an important clue to the character of Chinese thought in general" (Holzman 1956, 226).

ment that would have been the forced acquisition of a disciple (cf. Defoort 2012). In this dialogic style, an exchange conducted in truth always implies the reluctance of one of the interlocutors to engage in the exercise. Dialogue then arises on the verge of an "in spite of myself", on the basis that (as Confucius famously puts it) "I would prefer not to speak [*yu yu wu yan* 予欲無言]" (*Analects* 17.19).

– Finally, there is what one might call the "democratic" style of dialogue, the inspiration for which is not only valid for political exercise but also applies to certain models of interreligious dialogue for example. Its principle is that *reciprocal listening must be transformative for all partners who enter into an empathic understanding of the other's positions and experiences.* Such reciprocity is triggered by the necessity of finding a "third term" position which allows decision, coexistence, or (at the very least) continuation of the exchange, as the case may be. Dialogue is then a *producer of truth* in ways other than those provided by the logical confrontation of possibly contradictory or reconcilable assertions: it is the reciprocity of transformations that founds the truth that it establishes. One may here refer to Habermas: "[With the development of democratic societies], the authority of the holy is gradually replaced by the authority of an achieved consensus" (Habermas 1987, 77). And elsewhere: "Only those norms can claim to be valid that meet (or could meet) with the approval of all affected in their capacity as participants in a practical discourse" (Habermas 1990, 93).

More generally, we could label *performative dialogues* all those in which the trust placed in the interlocutor and in the transformative character of the dialogic experience is engaged, and *constative dialogues* those that mean to verify a conformity of fact or opinion, or an adequacy of the theory to the facts. Ordinarily, dialogues do not entirely fall into one or the other of these categories, which rather constitute poles to which a lived dialogue (or its written expression) comes more or less close. It is possible to consider dialogic styles as so many *language games*, the rules of which are associated to different styles of life.[132] In this

132 Wittgenstein uses the term "language games" more flexibly than his commentators sometimes acknowledge. I understand and use the term as he defines it very simply as soon as it appears in his lexicon: "Ways of using signs simpler than those in which we use the signs of our highly complicated everyday language" (Wittgenstein 1969, 17). The fact of using the operational concept of "language game" in order to approach a phenomenon as fluid as the multiplicity of dialogues experience obviously poses a problem. Only the creative openings that such usage allows for can justify it, and it is therefore for the reader to judge.

approach, each dialogic style is a system defined by rules, and these rules allow for a set of "thought experiments".[133]

There is however a major difference between the Wittgensteinian "language game" and the actual practice of dialogue: if the rules governing the former are intangible, the characteristic of a lived dialogue is precisely that *the rules governing the interlocution will constantly change over the course of the exchange.* Actually, Wittgenstein himself offers a vivid example of everyday adaptiveness:

> We can easily imagine people amusing themselves in a field by playing with a ball like this: starting various existing games, but playing several without finishing them, and in between throwing the ball aimlessly into the air, chasing one another with the ball, throwing it at one another for a joke, and so on. And now someone says: The whole time they are playing a ball-game and therefore are following definite rules at every throw. [...] And is there not also the case where we play, and make up the rules as we go along? And even where we alter them as we go along.
>
> (*PI* 83; Wittgenstein 1972 [1953], 39)

We experience the ever-changing character of everyday dialogue on a daily basis: the exchange with a stranger requires avoiding at the start certain subjects (money, family) and certain ways of expressing oneself (cracking a joke may be risky). The way the exchange evolves will modify the rules in question, in general to make them more flexible, but also sometimes to make them stricter if certain sensitive subjects or ways of speaking have been spotted. While generally obeying a much slower tempo, intellectual exchanges obey comparable evolutions: the few simple instructions that govern a debate at its beginning will be complexified over the course of the interaction, as the interlocutors negotiate not only on the substance of their exchange but also on the terms governing its rules and dynamic: Chinese and Western philosophers discuss less about "the nature of reality" than on the legitimacy and communicability of the logic and approaches that enter the discussion. Of course, certain styles of dialogue (legal debate, for example) leave very little room for the negotiation or renegotiation of rules, while others (interreligious dialogue as well as comparative philosophy) seem primarily concerned with achieving an agreement on the rules which govern them. The attention we pay to the ongoing transformations in the rules of exchange leads us to go beyond an understanding of dialogic styles as so many "closed systems".

At first glance, the more strongly the formal rules of exchange are codified (as they are, for example, in the scholastic *disputatio*), the "purer" may look the insights allowed by the dialogue. However, one may wonder whether insights do

133 For an example of a Socratic dialogue that presents itself at its beginning as governed by rules similar to the ones governing a "language game", see *Gorgias*, 449c–d.

not surge in the freedom that a "side step" away from the rules may allow rather than in striving for perfect formal expression. It is less the *formalism* of the rule that makes possible the vigor and rigor of an intellectual and spiritual experience than the *radicality* of this same rule, radicality manifested by the extent of the displacement that each of the interlocutors needs to take – displacement from a specialized lexicon, from the academic stage, or yet from one's ordinary life setting.

What precedes can be summarized as follows: (a) different dialogic styles function as so many language games, (b) the rules of which can be negotiated and updated as the exchange progresses, (c) thus blurring the operation of closure of such games, (d) and such language games are all the more "real" as the radicality of the rules which govern the exchange provokes a thought experience transformative of one's life-style.

A Mode of Inhabitation

The constitutive relationship which unites the notions of dialogue and culture is made evident by the sole fact that the place where the passage from "nature" to "culture" takes place is *language.* The arbitrariness of language means that it cannot result from human nature, even if it is inscribed in it. A given language, associated to a collective memory and history, configures a human group. At the same time, human corporeality (nature) is at stake in language (one speaks with the totality of one's body), and thereby in culture. Corporeality continues to be expressed in particular in the privileged place that art holds in any culture and, more generally, in the way in which each culture defines a way of *inhabiting the world.* It is by defining how it relates to the corporeality that founds it that a culture specifies its (artistic, relational, or yet culinary) "styles" – and "dialogical styles" are parts of this cultural set.

The above seems to hint at the *a priori* impossibility of intercultural dialogue, or even of any dialogue between members of different communities, if it was a question of wanting to put in relation mutually unintelligible languages: "We bring numerous only loosely connected languages from the loosely connected communities that we inhabit" (Hacking 1986, 458). However, as we will now see, dialogic styles, as rooted as they are in the particularities of the cultures in which they find form, are also the vectors by which these same cultures are permeable to others, and thus contribute to forge forms of universality.

As already noted, "speaking" is the locus where the incessant (and reciprocal) passage from nature to culture (from corporeality to arbitrariness) takes place. So much so that one can wonder if (as Rousseau wanted it to be) *singing* does not precede *speaking*, if the full deployment of one's voice – progressively detached from

the cry so as to become a controlled mode of expression – is not what leads ultimately to articulate speech. However, one can consider in the fact of "speaking" not the act but rather the capacity that authorizes it: the capacity of human organs to emit articulate sounds. The phonatory apparatus is to singing what the foot is to dancing: an immediate bodily anchoring, the use of which can gradually be freed from the constraints imposed by both the subject's primary awkwardness and the requirements associated with survival. It is on this basis that a "social capacity" of singing and dancing develops, which codifies and enriches its cultural expressions.

If song and dance can legitimately appear to be present in any culture and society, the ability to draw lines (to draw figures, design symbols, paint) seems to be just as important for linking nature (here, manifested in the potential shown by the human hand) to symbolic arbitrariness. When the hand is not used for activities directly useful to the subject (grasping or making an object), it explores by drawing the animality from which it proceeds: as shown by parietal paintings, natural forms, animals and even abstract and symbolic forms refer to the "naturalness", which it is now imparted to human gestures to control, as song and dance also do through the symbolic figuration that they perform in space and time. The solidarity of song, dance and drawing stems from their joint symbolic framing of the space-time where walking, speaking and gesturing can then meaningfully take place.

Here, Merleau-Ponty goes a long way: "The first drawings on cave walls were confronting the world as [a reality] 'to paint' or 'to draw', and were thus calling for an indefinite future of painting. This is why they 'speak' to us and why we respond to them with metamorphoses through which they collaborate with us" (Merleau-Ponty 1960, 75 [my translation]).[134] The observation is of primary importance: While they do rely upon the natural capacities of the man to draw, prehistoric paintings nevertheless ground a type of universality which, from the start, is not of the order of our "natural capacities" but rather of "cultural dialogue". First, they are already "dialogical" because they place humankind and the world in a relationship that the entire history of painting will develop – they are the basis of a first "dialogue", that of humankind and its environment, precisely because drawing defines the world as an "environment" to inhabit. Second, they are "dialogical" *a posteriori*, insofar as the gesture of the first painters has called for our task to continue *to inhabit the world by representing it.*

134 The original French reads: "Les premiers dessins aux murs des cavernes posaient le monde comme 'à peindre' ou 'à dessiner', appelaient un avenir indéfini de la peinture, et c'est ce qu'il fait qu'ils nous parlent et que nous leur répondons par des métamorphoses où ils collaborent avec nous."

In each case considered, the passage from walking to dancing, from speaking to singing, and from grasping to tracing includes both a caesura and a continuation. The caesura that takes place is, one might say, a *dialogical rupture:* human representations reveal the anchoring of humankind in its "nature" by simultaneously uncovering the fragility of a symbolic order that no gesture can close and that remains alive by the very fact that it continuously evolves throughout dialogue and exchange.

A Fragile Access to Universality

Dialogic styles produced by various cultural matrices entertain among them relationships marked with the seal of universality. Paradoxically, such an imprint comes from the fact that these relationships need to be constantly reworked and continued. There is by nature an *incompleteness* of all dialogues. They can be taken up, pursued, amplified, distorted by other dialogic styles as they travel through space and history. Even today, the *Analects* of Confucius, Socratic or Gospel dialogues as well as scholastic controversies are being continued to the exact extent that their overtures allow them to be reopened. The vulnerability of dialogue is what makes its continuation possible, because particular dialogues can be interrupted and started again, their rules can be negotiated, and their expressions indefinitely transformed.

Dialogic styles are called to be continued and reshaped both by the dialogical experience itself and by the concomitant evolution of the styles of life that first founded them (the ones of the communities gathered around Confucius or Jesus, or the University of Paris at the time of Thomas Aquinas…). We dialogue with because *we live with.* Sometimes, we "live together" without belonging to the same group (this is the case in all multicultural contexts), a situation in which dialogue becomes a necessity: *dialogue or death* – this is often the alternative. The advent of the world *oikumene* illuminates and directs the interconnection of dialogic styles as well as the transformations in the lifestyles associated with them.

Dialogue should then be made a regulating idea, animated by three principles which turn out to be both constative and programmatic: (a) The historical and cultural variety of dialogic styles prohibits any of them from being established as a norm. (b) The current strength of the idea of "dialogical style" (with the Western sources that shape and limit it, as suggested earlier) comes from the way dialogic styles developed in different contexts throughout history are now brought together and transformed. (c) However, the fact that these dialogic styles meet and are transformed also modifies, in a very progressive way, the very modalities of the meeting: a "common habitation" of the *oikumene* virtually leads to the emergence

of a "meta-dialogic style", this from the confluence of dialogic styles that enter in contact. To put it otherwise, dialogic styles are universalized (and become factor of universalization) through the fluidity which they exhibit or progressively develop. Fluidity makes a third party enter the game in turn, share the rules of the language game that is played, and, by sharing them, expand and transform them little by little. The more a dialogic style is anchored in living relationships, the more it is inscribed in a given time and an environment, the more it is marked by sinuosity, fluidity – and the more it deploys its own charge of universality, because it lends itself to being creatively continued. Intellectual history could be seen as the fabric of an unfinished conversation, admittedly often cut off but always expecting to be furthered.

Modes of Reading

It is from such a perspective that we can now fruitfully tackle the second question raised at the end of the introduction to this chapter: How can we read and interpret texts (classics) interculturally?[135] I will start again from a statement by Roger Ames. As we will see, the thesis, though accurate in its core, may be weakened by a propensity to systematicity that weakens its relevance:

> There is a failure of interpreters to be conscious of and to take fair account of their own Gadamerian "prejudices." They offer the excuse that they are relying on some "objective" lexicon when the truth of the matter is that this lexicon is itself heavily colored with cultural biases, thereby betraying their readers not once, but twice.
>
> (Ames 2001, 22)

Gadamer actually offers a defense of "prejudice" (*Vorurteil*), described as the necessary path through which "understanding" can gradually take shape. Whereas "prejudice", in English as in German, first designates a judgment passed before all facts have been examined (which may sometimes be justified), the Enlightenment period gives the word the meaning of "ungrounded judgment", ungrounded insofar it refers to the tribunal of "tradition" rather than to the one of "reason". A critical systematization that leads Gadamer to famously declare: "there is a prejudice against prejudices in general" (Gadamer 1990 [1960], 291 – my translation from the original German). For Gadamer, philosophical hermeneutics needs to go through a deconstruction of the anti-prejudices prejudice... We need to recog-

135 I provide in this section a modified, shortened version of theses first published in Vermander (2022c), 87–125.

nize and elucidate our prejudices, even sometimes to critically confirm the validity of some of them, rather than to endeavor to eradicate them as a matter of principle. Let me acknowledge at this stage that the criticisms directed towards the Gadamerian hermeneutics are many: it runs the risk of dissolving the specificity of a given text into an ontology of language; it gives a normative role to the tradition as shaping our sense of aesthetic appreciation; it makes "prejudices" constitutive of our reading. Denis Thouard (Thouard 2002) and others have tried to sketch out the model of a (post-Gadamerian) "critical hermeneutics", which among other features, rehabilitates the philological dimension of the hermeneutical endeavor. I appreciate the fact that these attempts give their full importance to textual criticism as well as to the study of the context and conditions of production of the corpus. I still think that Gadamer's approach (a) can be understood and practiced without falling into the traps highlighted by critical hermeneutics; (b) that it remains central to a *philosophical* thinking on what hermeneutic entails. This being said, I will soon point out some limitations of the Gadamerian project when it comes to the setting-up of a dialogic reading of texts coming from different traditions.

Let us now walk the road that opens up in front of us once we renounce the idea that we could be radically freed from "prejudices" when entering a given cultural corpus – ours or another. "Understanding", for Gadamer, is more than the subjective operation of a "I": "understanding" entails to recognize that we are inserted into an uninterrupted process of transmission where the past and the present constantly meet (Gadamer 1990 [1960], 295). Such an approach does not teach us how to read Chinese (or Western) classics but it certainly speaks to us of what is at stake in the very act of reading and "understanding".

What does it mean to refer to "my" tradition? It is clear that such an act of appropriation is often akin to a claim for identity mixed with intellectual fantasies: one may refer to one's tradition and yet never take the time to read its foundational texts and appreciate its basic tenets. Actually, people who like most to refer to their cultural roots are often the same who develop a stultified version of what such tradition corresponds to. The fact remains that I necessarily come from a tradition that guided me throughout my psychic, intellectual and spiritual development. And this tradition has determined the set of my "prejudices". This is where we meet with Gadamer's reflection on "prejudice" and the debates which resulted from it:

Protesting against the negative connotation of the term, Gadamer finds in prejudices the concrete conditions which shape our experiences, as prejudices function as *anticipations* by which access to the world opens up. At the same time Gadamer recognizes the need to discriminate between prejudices that need to be overcome by critical reason and those in which an embodied human experience is rooted. Still, the criteria for such discrimination have been the subject of many of the criti-

cisms leveled at Gadamer, which do not need to be detailed here. Gadamer offers a general response to these criticisms by locating the horizon of understanding in an "in-between" (*Zwischen*): "understanding" supposes a distance, but a distance which is not insuperable. "Understanding" also supposes belonging to a community, but through a mode of belonging that remains flexible and open. The very act of understanding starts from presuppositions rooted in a given tradition, presuppositions that lead me to discern within a text the "strangeness" which challenges my tradition and allows it to be enriched – a strangeness that the objectivity of historical knowledge cannot point out and that a total closure on my tradition makes me unable to accept. Interpretation and understanding are located in-between tradition (rooted in "prejudices") and objectified knowledge (Gadamer 1990 [1960], 317).

Understanding itself as a reflexive return upon one's tradition, the Gadamerian hermeneutics has not been devised in order to reflect about the experience of dialogically reading the classics of *another tradition* – and reading them in their strangeness which, as in a mirror, speaks of the "strangeness" of the texts to which I am used to refer as being "mine". Still, Gadamer allows for such opening: hermeneutics, he writes, is "participation in a common meaning" (Gadamer 1990 [1960], 297). Now – and the point is of great importance for the journey outlined here – a "common meaning" is constructed in a dialogical way by checking whether my understanding meets that of the other (without necessarily identifying with it). We generally progress in our understanding of an artwork or of a written text – whether this work belongs to our own cultural continent or to that of another community – by deepening our distance from the "pre-understanding" of the work which was obscuring its access. Even in the case of a work that belongs to my own cultural world, a taking of distance (akin to the fact of submitting oneself to the gaze of someone else) turns out to renew my understanding of the cultural expression that I approach. In this respect, all hermeneutics is potentially transcultural, because it needs to carry me beyond my original sphere. Gadamer sums it up by saying that distance (and first of all temporal distance between the work and me) is constitutive of meaning: "As soon as one understands, one understands *differently*" (Gadamer 1990 [1960], 302). This stress on "in-betweeness", on the distance through which meaning is produced, on the inner transformation that takes place as one understands the Other (be the Other a text, an artwork or a person) is what leads Gadamer to consider hermeneutics as a necessarily dialogical endeavor. Entering into dialogue means to think *with* others, and then to consider in return "Oneself as Another" (as Paul Ricoeur puts it). This thread of thought will be dominant in Gadamer's works after the publication of *Truth and Method.*

"Strategic", Naïve" and "Symptomatic" Readings

Keeping in mind the framework developed above, I now intend to formalize models through which to identify the variety of reading operations of which the (Chinese) classics were and still are the subject. Recognizing that the act of reading is characterized by a ductility, an inventiveness of which no modeling can capture the flow, I draw here the outline of seven modes of reading, and I will try at the same time to show how the limits specific to each of these modes allow and sometimes require the passage from the one to the other.

A classic text is usually not discussed "for itself". Its inclusion in an officially sanctioned cultural and/or educational corpus inscribes it within the strategy of the one who places it there: the text becomes a point of anchorage for a given cultural and national community; it transmits a vision, the acquisition of which conditions the mode of reading. It is gathered among other texts, their totality defining the boundaries of cultural and behavioral options considered acceptable by a collective. In other words, the determination of the corpus as the well as the mode of reading the classics determine who holds power and what legitimates it. In Han China, the shaping of state ideology is linked to the determination of a "system of the Classics". They offer the pattern of the cosmological system within which the Emperor plays an ordering role, a role both justified and tempered by the literati, the only ones able to remonstrate with him. Any conflict around the interpretation of the texts becomes of itself a political conflict. It is this observation that leads Anne Cheng to write: "The question of the truth of the Classics has never been asked systematically. [...] Rather, it was the way of understanding and interpreting them that was the problem" (Cheng 1984, 24).

Identifying the strategy that determines a given "mode of reading" does not in any way invalidate the latter. It is merely a way to attempt at "reading the reading" underwent by other readers. It becomes an enterprise of self-elucidation if I consider my own way of engaging with the text, discovering for myself that "reading is [always] at the service of an intention" (*intentioni enim servit lectio*).[136] However, when a reading strategy becomes conscious of its own premises, the reader is faced with a choice: either she pursues her path as if self-awakening had not happened, and then reading dries up, as the text has become consciously instrumentalized. Or, perhaps, the self-elucidation that the reader has reached leads her to engage into another reading mode.

In a way, any reading of the classics can only begin by obeying a given strategy: whoever studies them from within the cultural system that has canonized them

136 Guillaume de Saint-Thierry, *Lettre aux frères du Mont-Dieu*, quoted in De Certeau (2013), 205.

does so on the basis of the logic that justified their insertion. Conversely, whoever discovers them from outside necessarily confronts them with the logic of the corpus in which she has grown up, in a way that will be refined as the knowledge of the new textual continent deepens. In any case, the elucidation of my prejudices leads me to want to reach an opposite kind of reading, to approach the text "as it is given", entering a form of "second naivety". The more we discover our presuppositions and our cultural baggage, the more we wish to read with an "empty mind" (*xu xin* 虛心), as Zhu Xi invites us to do, as this would be the only way to capture "the meaning of the Sages [of the authors]" (*The Art of Reading* II 讀書法下). Taking into account the rich philosophical history of the character *xu* 虛, it is necessary to read Zhu Xi's proposition in all rigor: an emptied mind is one which, in its interior, brings to their *realization* (which makes actual, real) the potentialities present in the text that is read.[137]

The desire to enter into a text "as it is given" probably constitutes a mere utopia. When, for example, one studies Chinese texts dealing with Ritual, a careful reading necessarily raises questions that make the reader swiftly take distance from the text: what is actually at stake behind the question of etiquette? How and why is such topic located at the center of philosophical and political elaborations? What other issues does it correlate with? In other words: the "second naivety" (i. e., the wish to forsake any "strategic" intention in reading) does not of itself tell the reader *how to read.* It can even reify a question originally destined to remain in flux: how do we take into account the fact that, when reading *Laozi* or the *Analects*, it is often difficult to determine "what the text is talking about?" To borrow from Northrop Frye's famous saying: "The axiom of criticism must be, not that the poet does not know what he is talking about, but that he cannot talk about what he knows" (Frye 1957, 5). The sentence is illuminating when applied to ancient Chinese texts in which the subject matter appears ever-shifting, evanescent, elusive. This is the case, of course, for the *Laozi*, of which we cannot say whether it is a political, mystical, bodily techniques-oriented, cosmological or yet military treatise (all of the above at the same time, and none of it), but the same observation applies in many ways to the *Mencius* or to encyclopedic treatises such as *Huainanzi* and *Guanzi.* If we widen its field of application, Frye's axiom undermines the dream of an original transparency of the text to which the reading could reach by dint of making himself "innocent" by going beyond successive strata of interests and prejudices. Any text undermines the innocence of anyone who claims to read it "as it is given", if only because the author always provides us with some-

137 On the hermeneutic of Zhu Xi, see Berthrong (1991).

thing other than what she was intending to offer: the act of reception changes the nature of the gift.

What I call here "symptomatic reading" corresponds to the search throughout the text for a reality other than the one it seems to speak of – like the therapist who, in the patient's words, listens to the symptoms of what is not said and perhaps not "known" by the patient (at the very least, "she cannot talk about what she knows", as Frye's quote was stating). For example, reading the *Odes*, Marcel Granet finds in them the structure of the seasonal renewal festivals held in the peasant society of ancient China. In *Danses and Légendes de la Chine ancienne*, a work subsequent to *Fêtes et chansons anciennes de la Chine*, the symptomatic reading undertaken by Granet is further theorized upon in Chinese historical accounts, Granet does not find a source of facts to be verified. Rather, he seeks to rediscover the *mental schemas* which organize the selection and the writing of facts presented as "historical", without worrying whether these facts are historical or legendary. The work performed by the imagination on the stories transmitted by tradition, which eventually results in the fixation of the canonical texts, is not primarily of an individual nature: it reveals to us collective representations that we would not reach otherwise.

Confronting the Text as a Text

The reading methods mentioned so far (strategic, "immediate", and "symptomatic") have a common premise, that of taking the text as a *given*. It is against this premise that the "history of forms and sources" works. Taken to the extreme, this mode of reading questions the existence of the very object – the text – it is working upon. The history of forms and sources constitutes the model for the "scholarly" reading of the classics, the one that has dominated the academic field since the second half of the 19th century. Beyond the subdivisions that could be introduced into it, the history of forms and sources approaches the text as a collation of small units corresponding to a micro-form (for example, the proverb). First theorized and implemented in the context of biblical research, this approach greatly influenced how translators and commentators still measure up to Chinese classics today. It leads the critical reader to see all the levels above the micro-unit as the result of an editorial collation, on the whole not very significant: the text, basically, is always "poorly composed"...

In its beginnings, such a line of research started from the idea that the comprehension of texts could only be achieved by retracing the course of their formation and by going back to their source, ridding them of the successive layers added by the tradition. Such an effort involved identifying the *forms* taken by the texts. A

form is the set of elements that make up the same type of conventional literary unit. Since a form arises in a given situation (a death occurring in a family generates the use of the literary genre of the funeral notice, a harvest festival triggers the genre of songs found in the Hebrew Psalms or in the *Classic of Odes. Formgeschichte* (Form criticism) first seeks to identify the *Sitz im* Leben (setting in life) which produces such and such a type of form. However, after World War II, a current often referred to as *Redaktionsgeschichte* (Redaction criticism) partly reoriented the field of research, pointing out that the evangelists did original work determined by the theology they intended to develop; hence the renewed importance to be given to the study of the editorial framework that they had constructed – while nevertheless keeping a historicist perspective: the project of locating the authors and their editorial intentions always implies concentrating on the "anomalies", the "inconsistencies", "contradictions", traces of modifications that the text would have undergone during its development. Today, whatever their differences, *Formgeschichte* and *Redaktionsgeschichte* have combined into what one might call the modern historical-critical method. The historical-critical method is now a prerequisite for any attempt to read the classics. This does not mean that it is unsurpassable. The logic that it deploys cannot amount to the ultimate erasure of the text (and therefore of the very possibility of reading) but rather to the diversification of the text considered into its successive or competing states. The question then becomes to know by which means to relaunch the act of reading.

The realization that a text takes shape through the editorial transformations that it undergoes unveils continuous "textual chains" in place of texts clearly distinguished from one another. In the context of our subject matter, the highlighting of such textual chains triggered renewed interest in the Chinese commentarial tradition (see Henderson 1991). For cultures that see themselves as based on a canon, the approach to the latter was framed by the work of commentators who canonized works that in the process became "Classics". This *modus lectionis* is particularly characteristic of China. As a consequence, Chinese thought and science has been shaped through commentaries on these Classics. At the same time, the question of the distinction to be made between Classics and commentaries is both difficult and stimulating. Challenging a chronological schema which would make the commentaries (*zhuan* 傳) follow the Classics (*jing* 經), Anne Cheng notes that "the texts which we now qualify as canonical only became so when they were the subject of commentaries" (Cheng 1984, 14). So crucial was the importance of the commentarial genre that it has been said that there are as many versions of a given Classic

as there are commentaries on it.[138] The perpetuation and the influence of Classics (in particular of Confucian texts) would then be directly related to the elasticity conferred on them by the commentarial enterprise.

Some sinologists now claim that one needs to read Chinese classics "by and with the commentators". They rebel against the tendency, long dominant, to return to the "original text" against the barriers that the Chinese commentators would have erected to prevent its access. The detour through a commentary, or through the history of the reception of the text, is today rediscovered as an exegetical path in its own right. Among these attempts is the one led by Rudolf Wagner, for whom the famous commentary by Wang Bi (226–249) effectively discovers the structure of the *Laozi*. This commentary, writes Wagner, accomplishes three tasks: "the construction of the text into an understandable utterance; the explanation of the philosophic logic behind the text's statement; and the deconstruction of previous constructs enshrined in the mind of the reader" (Wagner 2000, 299). Wang Bi's personal genius led him to develop a highly original hermeneutical strategy while strictly adhering, from start to finish, to the need for internal consistency within the text. Wang Bi was particularly interested in the formal and structural processes of the *Laozi* as well as in its approach of language: the text of the *Laozi* provides us with the very principles that allow for its interpretation.

The genre and hermeneutical enterprise of the classical commentary are arguably not repeatable today. At its apex, its limitations were pointed out already. These limitations may have been triggered by the very success of the genre; essential turned out to be the interiorization allowed by the commentary, an interiorization equivalent to subjectivation. The most striking expression of what such interiorization eventually entails is that offered by Lu Jiuyuan 陸九淵 (1139–1192): "Classics comment upon me, and [by this very fact] I comment upon Classics [*liujing zhu wo wo zhu liujing* 六經注我, 我注六經]" (*Record of Words* I, Lu 1980, 399). This sentence is found in a "record of word" (an oral statement *yulu* 語錄), in which Lu responds to a disciple asking why the Master has not written any commentary of the Classics… Though strikingly short, Lu's answer is clear: a real commentary on Classics is that offered by an existence shaped by their content. From the Song dynasty onwards, the genre of the record taken on the basis of oral teaching, revelatory to a trend towards orality, created new exegetical paths. At the same time, the framework of the interlinear commentary continued to protect the canonical edifice until the beginning of the 20th century when the methodology

138 See Gardner (1990). See also Richard Lynn's introduction to his translation of *The Classic of Changes* (Lynn 1994).

propounded by the history of forms and sources brought together Chinese and Western philologists in a common critical project.[139]

Besides a renewed focus on the commentarial tradition, as described above, another hermeneutical project aims to overcome the dead ends where the historical-critical method engages the reader. This project, which directly challenges the *Formgeschichte* tradition, is centered on "structural rhetoric": the latter method would make it possible to understand the organization of our texts, and therefore to consider them again as "texts" in their own right. What is meant by "structural rhetoric"? In the tradition of the history of sources and forms, one of the reasons that explains the uneasiness felt when reading texts seen as a collation of independent units undoubtedly stems from the primacy that its Western promoters gave (without even discussing it) to Greco-Latin rhetoric – the descriptive and normative model of the composition of a text. Any text that did not fit these rhetorical rules, could not be really "organized", and therefore had to be dissected in order to trace the history of the (awkward) collage of which it was necessarily the result.

That the text can and should be read, understood and appreciated according to the rhetorical processes that structure it is in no way a new assertion. Nevertheless, if from Aristotle to Cicero and Quintilian, Greco-Latin rhetoric was the object of an early theorization, it was much later that it was recognized that different cultures organize the structure and logic of the texts they produce in different ways (argumentative and/or narrative). The identification of the laws specific to Semitic rhetoric began to take place from the 17th century onwards, but these laws have been systematically explored only in recent times.[140] When it comes to Chinese rhetoric, its rules were somehow already theorized in the *Wenxin diaolong* (文心雕龍 – a title tentatively translated as *The Literary Mind and the Carving of Dragons*), a work by Liu Xie 劉勰 (465–522) that focuses not only on stylistic issues (with the *Zhuangzi* as a model) but also on compositional ones – and applies these same rules to itself. Much later on, some writers, including Japanese and Korean ones, turned towards the genre of "rhetorical commentaries", focusing not only on stylistics but also on textual structures. "Readers today do not comprehend the fundamental features of texts (*wenyi* 文義) they read", writes the Korean scholar Wi Paekkyu 魏伯珪 (1727–1798), before noting in a given passage of the *Mencius* the symmetry between its beginning and its end, a ring composition being thus established: "At the beginning of this paragraph, Mencius referred to the use of profit by the King. At the end, he referred to benevolence and rightfulness based on what

139 On the encounter between Western and Chinese philologists during the first decades of the 20th century, see Chang (2016).

140 See notably Douglas (2007); Meynet (2012); and my discussion of the debates awakened by the application of the methods of structural rhetoric to ancient Chinese Classics (Vermander 2021a).

was said before, and suddenly dismissed the King's opinion, saying 'Why must Your Majesty use that word profit?'"[141]

Leaving aside a focus on the text as a completed structure, framed for instance as a circle divided into a series of symmetrical fragments,[142] some recent works explore classical Chinese rhetoric as a device aimed at modifying the *habitus* (the usual way of behaving) of the one who enrolls under a given teacher.[143] In the Confucian universe, this perspective helps to strengthen the connection between ritual practices and ethos, on the one hand, and the texts that establish and comment on them, on the other. The *Analects* in particular would constitute a *rhetoric of ritualization:* intended effects on pupils were produced not by words alone but through a combination of discourse and ritualized conducts. Nevertheless, these approaches often fail to offer the sketch of a coherent textual frame, failing to show how the principles they enunciate practically apply. In contrast, the strength of the historical-critical approach remains to function on the hypothesis that the unveiling of such a frame, if it exists, matters less than that of the temporal process which led to the final editing of the text as we know it today.

The Text as Experience

The reading experience can be transfigured into a "garden of affects", writes Michel de Certeau: "The 'savors', the 'taste', the 'fervors' that punctuate it presuppose a reading made up of movements: *motions* and emotions are combined; the *affectus* involves and stimulates a *motus. Lectio* is therefore considered an *actio*" (De Certeau 2013, 208). Here, let us borrow an example taken from the ancient Chinese corpus. Asked to explain why Ritual is more important than food or the satisfaction of the sexual appetite, Mencius responds in the following way:

> By twisting your older brother's arm to take what he is eating, you could get food; you can't if you don't – will you twist his arm? By scaling the wall to the east of your property and kidnapping your neighbor's virgin daughter you could acquire a wife; you can't if you don't – will you go and take her away?

141 See You (2018), notably 506 and 510.

142 See Vermander (2021a); Pelkey (2021).

143 See Lu (1998); Mao (2007). Xioaye You asserts: "I would like to define rhetoric broadly as the art of modifying human minds and behaviors through symbols. I would argue that the *Analects* is a rhetoric on the multimodality of ritual symbols, dealing with the rhetorical process of symbolic identification and transformation in ritualistic performance" (You 2006, 429). For a different and most refreshing approach to Chinese rhetoric, based on its usage of humor: Harbsmeier (1989) and (1990).

> 紾兄之臂而奪之食，則得食；不紾，則不得食，則將紾之乎？踰東家牆而摟其處子，則得妻；不摟，則不得妻，則將摟之乎？
>
> (*Mencius* 6B.1.)

The emphasis of the text is on the twisted arm and the climbing of the wall: representing himself engaged in such an action, the listener or the reader realizes that the ritual is a question of life or death, as Mencius already had said about justice (*yi* 義), comparing life to fish and justice to bear's paw: the gourmet summoned to choose will not hesitate to sacrifice the first to keep the second (*Mencius* 4 A.10.). The saying it intended not only to inculcate a moral teaching but also to make one enter an experiential mode of knowledge.

Stanza 15 of the *Laozi* allows us to go one step further in our understanding of the way such "conceptual metaphors" work:[144] it describes the Sages "cautious as when crossing a river in winter [豫兮若冬涉川]", and "evanescent as ice that begins to melt [渙兮若冰之將釋]". The character *huan* 渙 (melting) corresponds to the 59th hexagram of the *Yijing:* the moment when the weak, through its dissemination, acts in accordance with the strong.[145] In *Laozi*, and beyond, metaphors often speak of a certain type of experiences: the ones that seem to happen in the same time as they are erased (hastening when crossing a river that at any time may start to melt). For there are experiences that require from us a special quality of attentiveness. They come and go throughout the flux of life: the wise traveler threads quickly and lightly on a surface where it is better not to stop. Likewise, the reader must focus not upon a state of things but rather upon a *movement.* If her mode of reading makes her enter into the very center of the text, it also prompts her not to dwell too long on the same text, not to substitute the text for lived experience.

It is likely that ancient Chinese texts were originally composed so as to engage the bodily act of memorizing and reading them aloud into the experience of what they were speaking about. In the context of the *Suwen* 素問 (*Basic Questions*), a medical text, Claude Larre rightly detects an almost therapeutic exercise of the breaths that is offered to the reciter: a Classic is first

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144 On the notion of "conceptual metaphor": Slingerland (2011).

145 A note from the *Oxford World's Classics* translation of *Laozi* illustrates how an essentially historical-critical reading orients and may distort the interpretation given to the text: noting that the incise of Laozi 15 mentioning the ice which is beginning to melt is not in the *Guodian* version, the translator treats it as a "footnote" and not as an integral part of the text. He therefore sees in it an almost superfluous addition, which describes the Sage remaining isolated (as when the melting ice isolates individuals on separate blocks of ice). The experience suggested by the text is seen in a different light when considering the received version on its own merit and giving its full importance to the mention of the melting ice (cf. Ryden 2008, 33 and 172).

> an expression of the vital breath. [...] The breath sustains the continuous flow of the discourse, at the same time as it deforms itself so as to allow the elementary articulation of the characters that organize the sentence into an intelligible whole. This is how one clears the ground for the hand [of the medical practitioner] that will abolish the anomaly and operate the cure.
>
> (Larre 1987, 17)

The thing is facilitated by the structure of the Chinese language, notes Claude Larre, because of the alternation between "full words" (loaded with semantic content) and "empty [or: hollow/function] words [*xuci* 虚词]" which articulate the sentence. The text then becomes "a kind of vertebrate whose movement is carried by function words", and the text thus appropriated by the body of the reader expresses the vital breath which organizes it and passes through it (Larre 1987, 17).

Reading the (Chinese) classics is an operation that can legitimately be carried out through each of the modes considered above, and which, perhaps, invites us to mobilize them in succession. However, in the dialogic perspective studied throughout this chapter, I put special emphasis on the two last modes of reading: structural and experiential.

The first mode focuses on the weft, the invisible weaving of the text, and on the way it articulates details into a whole. A given textual web structures the way of thinking of an era and/or of a cultural sphere. At the same time, its analysis unveils constants, structures of thought, that escape cultural and historical determinism. A linear structure (the one that goes "from A to Z", so to speak) better accommodates causal reasoning and logical progression. A circular structure (which links together the beginning of the text with its end) hints at the completion of a wholly ordered system of thought. Other ways of "composing" a text could certainly be deciphered. One should not attribute too easily such or such rhetorical genre to a culture or another. If some modes of writing indeed predominate at a given period of time, in a given environment, these same modes generally succeed each other, to the extent that their articulations become unintelligible at latter times. Mary Douglas has contrasted historical moments when "repleteness", closure, was preferred, and others privileging open-endedness. "Civilizations may rest on different principles of organization", Douglas was stating. At the same time, within each civilization, there is regular alternance between the stress on "cognitive coherence" and "cognitive opportunism", cognitive coherence showing affinities with ring composition, cognitive opportunism with open-ended (mostly linear) textual structures (Douglas 2007, 146–147).

A dual focus (focus on the way the subject's body is affected by the text, focus on rhetorical composition as revelatory of the mode of thinking that underlies a given textual production) helps us to enter into a cross-cultural, comparative reading of our respective canons. A text – a philosophical text – is not simply an ar-

rangement of notions. As far as it reflects a lived experience and a system of thought that remains alive, it is a living organism: it needs to be apprehended as a whole, as a space where breath circulates. The text is both skeleton and living flesh. Meetings among classics is as such akin to a meeting among persons, not to a comparative evaluation of the respective workings of two mechanics. This is why working with full texts – rather than selected excerpts and catalogues of concepts and definitions – is crucial: you need to meet with the entirety of the text – including its inconsistencies, hesitations and aporias. You need also to evaluate the *effects*, the *affects* that the text exercises upon you.

Some questions will help the reader to enter into dialogue with, say, Chinese classics, and then to reflexively return to the tradition she comes from: listening to the voice that pierces throughout the text, what seems to have been the experience proper to the author (the one triggered by a constant state of warfare for instance, as during the Warring States period in China), the experience that he tries to communicate to disciples and readers? What rhetorical means does the author use in his attempt to make disciples and readers share in the same experience and make it a "thought experience"? Again, let us think about the way Mencius makes all issues discussed become questions of life or death when drawn to their ultimate consequences. This is a rhetorical device; at the same time, it helps us to understand that "rhetoric" is not about empty words or mere "tricks": the rhetorical radicalization of the issues at stake does say a lot about the way Mencius understands humaneness and proper way of behavior. An additional question might be: what are the effects of the text upon myself, and how does its rhetoric influence the way I re-read my own experience, which the text may have reawakened?

The Text as Garden and Body

Let us go back to our "gardening" imagery, imagining textual productions as Chinese gardens. Chinese gardens are "texts" in their own way: you enter into them through an opening, an initial viewpoint (for instance, some gardens in Suzhou have doors shaped in the form of a pear). Such initial viewpoint displaces perspectives, it encourages us to look anew at what surrounds us. Besides, a garden obeys a specific structure, which conveys meaning, it leads us along pathways, and it inserts us into a microcosm, which may help us to think about our setting in the macrocosm. This is akin to what happens when we "stroll" throughout a text without hastening, letting the text lead us where it intends to.

Also, the dreams and worldviews that were embodied into the Chinese literati's psyche could be represented through the garden metaphor. Chinese gardens were often created by scholar-officials aspiring to escape the worries of their offi-

ces or who had fallen into disgrace. Accordingly, they could be seen as a dream land, a utopia, a labyrinth of hidden thought … As peaceful and serene as they remain today, they were built over a sea of worries and sufferings – hence the Buddhist undertones they so often possess.

However, first and foremost, a garden is a living body, complete with orifices, vessels and limbs. Orifices, first … The garden, a small and secluded place, endlessly increases its size through its internal divisions – mounds that break the perspective, walls running along the walkways, partitions all around its pavilions. But these partitions are pierced by openwork windows, round doors, and numerous small openings through which the walker can appropriate space and sight. The openings suggest the paths to be followed. Windows and doors gradually reveal the garden to our senses, as the painter's hand unfolds with pride and caution the scroll on which he made the roaring waterfall, the trail on the side of the mountain, the grove pines and the sea of clouds come to life… The garden indeed is a scroll, a miniature world opened up and enlarged by our walks and our whims. Pierced with orifices, the garden is irrigated by vessels through which life, breath and seasons circulate… Water animates a garden – water collected in a pond and divided into channels that flow in its interior, water that makes small garden rocks the mimes of formidable mountains. Then, irrigated by the vessels that transform it into a living body, the garden can deploy its limbs, taking the form of a lying dragon, a unicorn, or perhaps one of these Taoist immortals of whom we are not sure whether they are humans or gods. Its limbs are made of its eminences, these modest mountains that transform the pond into a sea, the channels into giant rivers, and the courtyards into continents.

Additionally, a garden can work as a metaphor for not only a text but also a system of thought that continues to grow and evolve, or yet for a community or any kind of living organism – and, ultimately, for the cosmos in its totality. The garden metaphor thus inserts the text (the Classic) into practices and representations from which it is in fact unbreakable.

Entering the garden has also led us to cross the threshold of "comparative philosophy" without having ever noticed it. For the use of the same metaphor helps us to envision the categories of "sameness" and "difference" by associating (rather than by opposing) them. *Sameness:* we are entitled to use the garden metaphor for speaking of all texts that help us to "experience" what it means to think – and therefore to think by ourselves – the way Kant was implying when propounding the *conceptus cosmicus* of philosophy. Gardens as a living space of organic growth speak of all processes of thought organized into a textual construction destined to be appropriated and continued by the reader. *Difference:* we are similarly entitled to contrast Chinese gardens with their French or English counterparts, thus underlining dissimilarities in atmosphere and arrangements. Leisurely pacing

gardens that all testify to the same life (and thought) process and yet that differ in the experience they convey does not mean to follow pre-ordained circuits. Wandering about, strolling back and forth, shifting from one path, one perspective to another – this is also part of the philosophical experience.

Beyond Comparative Classics

One may wonder whether the mode of entering into philosophical engagement through the structure/experiential reading of the classics I am suggesting here is not akin to a return to the *modus scholasticus* of "philosophizing" that Kant challenged in the lines evoked at the very beginning of this book. I rather think that this mode of comparatively reading our respective classics triggers two results that ultimately facilitate an understanding of philosophy that is "teleological", in the sense it fosters concerns (as well as a style of interaction) that are activated by a dynamic of continuous universalization.

The first result obtained by the comparative mode of reading described above is to develop a sense of empathy that roots itself into attentiveness – attentiveness to the *experience* and the *intention* that animate a given text, make it a whole, a living body. Let us come back to Gadamer: a "Classic", says Gadamer, is indeed a historical reality (*geschichtlich*) but a reality to which the historical consciousness (*historisch*) is subject insofar as what is "classic" is withdrawn from the fluctuations of time and from the variations of taste registered at a given time. We qualify a work as "classic" because we are aware of something permanent in it, independent of the circumstances. But since a classical work represents the fulfillment of a genre, the culmination of a given style at a given time, the concept also acquires historical significance. (Gadamer 1990 [1960], 292–294) "What in history asserts itself alive in the present is the Classic" (Zarader 2016, 216). Texts are not only objects of objectified knowledge, they continue to be carriers of a word addressed to us in the present. This also means that the empathy through which we are able to discern the present within the past extends to the one and the other tradition we are comparatively investigating. We do not need to "denigrate" or belittle our own tradition in order to discover the strength and novelty of another one, no more that the appreciation of our roots would signify a lesser interest for alternative ways to engage into the act of thinking. Even if his system may not allow for an explicit assertion of what follows, what Kant calls reflective teleological judgments (judgments informed by ends that are both necessary and universal) need to be informed by such empathy, reciprocally displayed and nurtured, and this precisely because they are directed by ends that are *necessary* (thus inscribed into the

human condition) and discovered as *universal* (the human condition being inscribed into our common *oikumene*).

Another result is induced by our comparative mode of reading: it allows us to proceed behind and beyond the texts that are read. The stress I have consistently put on the *intentio lectionis* and on the author's ground experience speaks of the fact that hermeneutical attentiveness first proceeds "below" the textual level: it unearths its source, what makes it alive. For the same reason, attentiveness, as displayed throughout the textual journey, projects itself into what the text from the beginning tends towards, the *ends* that it assigns to its readers. Our way of reading enables us to recognize that the text is not an end to itself. A Classic is not a "closed world". It is a vector that aims at drawing us back into the world, transformed by our reading experience. It is outside the classics, and mutually transformed by their reading, that people coming from various traditions are called to meet.

Interpretation and Inventiveness

We thus read *teleologically*, and this is what enables us now to speak of "comparative philosophy" as being carried by the text and yet liberated from the act of reading. The last section of this chapter sketches the task that reading comparatively allows us to engage in, freed from endless debates on texts and commentaries.

We all wish to experience "meaningful" encounters. What we aim at when expressing such a wish refers to an array of feelings and perceptions: some kind of *taste* developing throughout the exchange (the pleasure that arises from conversation, mixing of languages, exoticism, discovery, friendship perhaps); also, a mutual acknowledgment that reciprocal displacements are taking place in the process (broadening of views, change in opinions and prejudices, sharing of emotions and memories, be they collective or personal). Relationships transform, create, carry forward *meanings*, experienced as crystallized perceptions, evaluations and interpretations of facts, people, places, texts or events. Eventually, a "meaningful" relationship develops from or evolves into shared projects and practical cooperation in order to fulfill common objectives.

The first glimpse of "meaning" that appears in a transcultural exchange has to do with the discovery of some *commonality.* However, ordinarily such commonality is not of a positive nature but *rather of a negative one: it is about the sharing of crises and challenges.* This might be true within the framework of metaphysical or religious exchange (the sharing of the fact that we are all mortal beings), but also of cultural and social dialogue. Globalization is first and foremost the globalization of crises and challenges. Global warming, deforestation, waste of natural resources, migrations, crisis in the educational model represent challenges com-

mon to all of us, though with varying degrees of intensity and sometimes with stakes that may seem to (provisionally) differ (migration is a case in point), though their solutioning is wished for by all. The feeling of commonality might also arise from the collapse of traditional ways to understand one's world, identity and culture, from the spreading of a culture of violence at school or in society at large, or from the difficulty to implement mechanisms of harmony and reconciliation. What we first share is a feeling of urgency and disarray.

The second stage of the process is to realize anew the *variety of the cultural resources we mobilize or could mobilize for answering such challenges.* If we do confront common problems and crises, it is true also that there remain tremendous differences among worldviews rooted in Taoism, Buddhism, Islam, Christianity or among the core values found in Confucian, African or European societies. On life itself, on authority structures, on relationships with nature or with the Other, on processes of discussion and evaluation, our ground intuitions, logical approaches, canonical texts and ingrained norms of behavior are varied, divergent or contradictory. Furthermore, our cultural traditions are embedded into historical memories that conflagrate one with another. Discovering the wide array of our differences might be, at the same time, exhilarating and extremely puzzling. Thus, our perception of what might well be "meaningful" springs from the crux of "difference", as we ponder over what both unites and separates us.

This is where a strategic choice is to be made. Let me suggest that "meaning" continues to flow and to circulate when we decide to make this tremendous variety of cultural resources the toolbox that enables us to interpret anew our own tradition and culture. Our cultures, worldviews and creeds are being reformulated through the interpretative resources offered by the other cultures, worldviews and creeds – and this operation happens simultaneously for all participants in the exchange. Such interpretative process can become a sophisticated intellectual endeavor when, for instance, it aims at re-interpreting Christian theological categories through the concepts and vocabulary of Mahayana Buddhism – or at reading Chinese philosophical tradition through the conceptual arrangements found in the West, as were attempting to do some of the New Confucianists we encountered in the course of our third chapter. At times, the attempt to reinterpret one's tradition through the resources offered by another cultural corpus can be pretty straightforward. I remember a Chinese friend, expert in Daoist scriptures and history, whom I was asking what his projects were now that he had completed a major publication. He answered me that, for some time, his contacts with Christianity had convinced him that the success met by this particular religious form throughout the world had to do with its capacity to confront the challenges of modernity, making its thought and vocabulary evolve and develop with the modernization process. He wanted, he told me, to comparatively explore the ways through

which Daoism could similarly become a truly "contemporary" religious form. Similar reflections and intellectual endeavors have taken and are taking shape in innumerable minds and circles. Each time, the evolving relationship with the Other makes this very relationship the set of interpretative resources, through which I assess and reformulate my own identity. In this perspective, all cultures, creeds and worldviews are perpetually reshaped, are ever-evolving, and what defines them is never taken for granted but rather is being discovered *and* challenged throughout the process of exchange and interpretation. Thus, the core of our identity is never "behind" us, it is always "beyond"; it is related to the Other whose identity is similarly challenged and reshaped.

We enter into dialogue so as to cross-interpret our own tradition through the wisdom, sensitivity and tradition that belong to an Other by birthright, so to speak: we borrow our tools from another toolbox. Through this process, we invent "localized solutions" that have gone through a "globalized" interpretative process. At the same time, this ever-evolving reshaping of one's culture, creeds and worldviews does not lead to a confusion or a mix, it defines and sometimes sharpen one's sense of belonging and core values. Though identities are mobile and changeable, they are still discrete entities, and the solutions to our common challenges will remain localized, different in the way they are conceived of and implemented. However, throughout the interpretative process, these particular solutions will considerably vary from the ones suggested by the traditional understanding of one's culture and identity, and the array of solutions devised from one's culture or group to another will then be legitimately understood as a correlated set of attitudes, choices and decisions.

Translation, Memory and Imagination

Two points here deserve qualifications. First, the standpoints that define people's and cultures' sense of crisis and identity take place in the diversity of their languages – verbal and non-verbal. Furthermore, within a given society, endeavoring to mutually "translate" the various sets of symbolic and rational languages that coexist within the social and political field is also a requisite. For instance, marginal groups are confronted with a discourse originating from power centers, such discourse being also legitimized by the style and vocabulary of globalized, technocratic English. In this perspective, intercultural exchange is about allowing a group of people to express itself in its mother tongue while giving them the means to understand other participants' mother tongues and being understood by them. This is a highly sophisticated process – and yet, a task that requires much more than the setting-up of sophisticated technical procedures. In this respect, the "global ethics"

that the world community is insistently looking for is inseparable from the translation process itself. In many ways, it is the fact of sticking to the interpretative process that constitutes the global ethics. To put it another way, a global ethics *is* a language ethic.

Another point bears upon the model of interaction sketched above: in the process I am sketching, particular importance is to be given to "memory" and "imagination". Here, another metaphor may be of help: in Renaissance Europe, the construction of a "Memory Palace" (part of the *ars memorativa*) was a way to remember a store of knowledge, the material repository of which you could not easily access. By walking through the rooms of a building that you had built in your mind, you were able to find the image associated with a set of data at the place where you had stored it. The striking character of the images involved was a determining factor for memorizing them easily. A second principle was equally important: "To everything that we wish to remember, wrote Matteo Ricci introducing the method to the Chinese, we should give an image, and to every one of these images we should assign a position where it can rest peacefully until we are ready to reclaim it through an act of memory" (Spence 1984, 92, referring to Ricci 1596).

Due to his Jesuit background Ricci may have been especially sensitive to the role played by memory for educating people who would be skilled both at self-knowledge and at successful communication: Ignatius of Loyola' *Spiritual Exercises* put the stress on "memory and imagination": during the course of a spiritual retreat, one's time of prayer starts with "a composition, seeing the place": one focuses on a "corporeal place, as for instance a temple or mountain" or else on representing "with the sight of the imagination" an invisible reality.[146] Imagination works together with memory. *Remembering* is a struggle against forgetting, a struggle that requires from you to mobilize some means to that effect. Ricci speaks of letting an image you have stored "in a position where it can rest peacefully until we are ready to reclaim it", but this involves having first arranged the respective positions of your troves of images through reflective attempts at optimal architectural disposition, to be repeated each time you enlarge the Memory Palace.

Interestingly enough, Ricci recommends to build up *fictive* Palaces of Memory – or at least "half-fictive (*ban shi ban xu* 半實半虛)" (Ricci 1596) – rather than following an existing model. This way, he says, the Palace can be expanded at will, whereas relying on something one knows too well limits the future expansion of the Palace and the subsequent storage space. The Memory Palace stores the stories and figures that we gather in the course of our quests, *but it does so within a struc-*

146 Cf. Ignatius of Loyola, *Spiritual Exercises*, n. 47 (Fleming 1996, 42).

ture, a form, a space that is called to perpetually expand. This might be an apt metaphor for speaking about the continuous enlarging of our sensitivity and intellectual empathy called for by the very fact of entering a new model of intercultural dialogue. Understood this way, "comparative philosophy" requires from us to perpetually broaden the space in which we meet in truth with the Other, so we may be mutually transformed, evolving and growing in ways that we could never have foreseen.